

Who Leaves Teaching, and Why?

The Profile of Teacher Attrition in the United States, 2005–2025

José Elías Durán Roa¹

July 2026

Abstract

Who leaves the teaching profession, and why? I build twenty annual panels of American school teachers by linking consecutive rotations of the Current Population Survey between 2005 and 2025, following 174,872 degree-holding teachers for twelve months each, and I measure attrition with a strict definition that counts as leavers only those who do not return to teaching in any later interview, although the survey design caps observation at sixteen months, so returns after more than a year go undetected. Every year 15.1 percent of teachers leave the profession without an observed return, a rate that has risen by four points in two decades almost entirely through switching to other occupations rather than exits from the labor force. A probit on the full set of observed characteristics shows that weak attachment to the job, rather than demographics, drives exit, since part-time work raises the probability of leaving by 11 points and private-sector employment by 7, in every subsample, while higher pay retains. Fertility operates only through women, as a new baby raises mothers' exit probability by 5 points and leaves fathers unchanged, and Black and non-citizen teachers leave significantly more. The typical leaver is a late-career woman, working part-time and disproportionately in a private school, whose predicted exit probability of 37 percent is two and a half times the average. One in six measured leavers is back teaching within three months, so cheap re-entry pathways can recover part of the outflow.

¹PhD Candidate in Economics, University of Alicante, and Research Intern at the OECD Directorate for Education and Skills. E-mail joseelias.duranroa@ocde.org and joduran@ua.es. The views expressed here are mine and do not represent those of the OECD. All remaining errors are my own.

1. Introduction

Who leaves teaching, and why? Few questions in the economics of education carry more policy weight. Teachers are the main school input in the production of achievement (Rivkin, Hanushek and Kain, 2005; Chetty, Friedman and Rockoff, 2014), replacing a leaver is expensive and disruptive for the students left behind (Ingersoll, 2001; Ronfeldt, Loeb and Wyckoff, 2013), and the fear of a post-pandemic exodus has moved retention to the center of the education policy debate. In this paper I answer the question for the United States with twenty years of nationally representative panel data, following every teacher the Current Population Survey (CPS) observes between 2005 and 2025 for twelve months and asking who leaves the profession, where they go, and what predicts their departure.

What is known so far comes from three kinds of sources, each with a blind spot. The Teacher Follow-up Survey provides the official national attrition rate, 8 percent of public school teachers in 2021–22, but it runs only every few years, relies on self-reports, and observes leavers in a single retrospective questionnaire (NCES, 2024). State administrative records support the sharpest causal work, from the Texas panels of Hanushek, Kain and Rivkin (2004) to the Wisconsin pay reform of Biasi (2021) and the post-pandemic studies of Massachusetts, North Carolina and Arkansas (Bacher-Hicks, Chi and Orellana, 2023; Bastian and Fuller, 2023; Goldhaber and Theobald, 2023; Camp, Zamarro and McGee, 2025), but each covers one state and loses sight of a teacher the moment she leaves the state payroll, so it cannot say where leavers go. The existing national estimates from the CPS, finally, rely on the March supplement question about the job held one year earlier (Harris and Adams, 2007; Aldeman and Yi, 2025), a retrospective self-report collected in a single interview that yields annual leaving rates of 6 to 8 percent but is known to understate occupational change and cannot observe returns, a gap I replicate and dissect in Appendix A.

I take a different route through the same survey. The CPS interviews each household in two blocks of four months separated by eight, so an adult observed in year t can be re-interviewed in the same calendar month of $t+1$. I assemble all 251 monthly files between January 2005 and December 2025, link the interviews twelve months apart through household and person identifiers with demographic validation in the spirit of Madrian and Lefgren (2000), and obtain twenty annual panels covering 174,872 linked teachers. Because one in six apparent leavers is teaching again within three months, I measure attrition with a strict definition that counts as a leaver only a teacher who is out of teaching at the twelve-month link and in every re-interview after it. The design observes the destination occupation and labor force status of every leaver, carries the full set of covariates of the survey, from fertility events to union status and pay, and updates every month at essentially no cost.

Four findings summarize the paper. First, attrition is high and rising. Every year 15.1 percent of American teachers leave the profession without an observed return, up from about 13 percent in the mid 2000s to 17 percent in recent years, with a new high of 18.0 percent in 2024. Second, the rise is a reallocation rather than a withdrawal. Moves to other occupations account for almost all of it, exits into non-participation are flat, and 30 percent of leavers remain inside education in jobs other than classroom teaching. Third, attachment to the job, not demographics, predicts who leaves. Part-time teachers are 11.3 percentage points more likely to leave than full-time colleagues and private-school teachers 7.5 points more likely than public-school ones, against a baseline of 15 percent, while higher pay retains. Fertility operates only through women, since a new baby raises mothers' exit probability by 5.1 points and leaves fathers' unchanged, the national counterpart, half a century later, of the classic cohort evidence in Stinebrickner (2002). Fourth, geography lines up with what schools produce, since states with higher NAEP scores retain their teachers better.

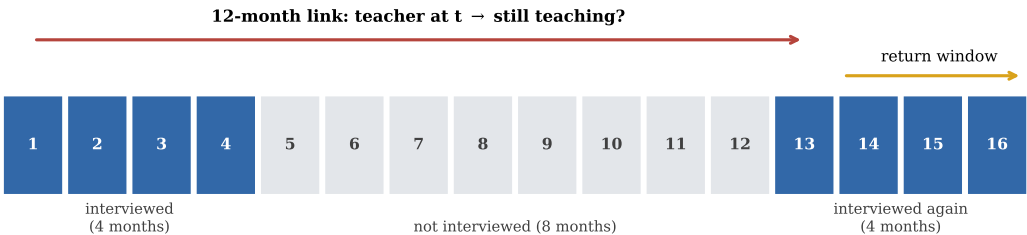
The paper makes three contributions to the United States evidence. The first is measurement. To my knowledge this is the longest, most frequent and most current nationally representative series of teacher attrition, and the first to purge temporary exits with a re-interview window rather than a single year-over-year comparison. The second is destinations. Administrative studies cannot observe a teacher once she leaves the public payroll and the follow-up surveys observe leavers only in survey years, whereas here every leaver carries an occupation code twelve months after baseline. The third is the breadth of correlates estimated jointly on national data, including the event of a birth as distinct from the stock of children, union membership, sector, hours and pay, in one model with year fixed effects. None of the estimates is causal, and I offer them as the descriptive infrastructure that the causal literature, which is overwhelmingly single-state, currently lacks at the national level (Nguyen, Pham, Crouch and Springer, 2020).

The rest of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 describes the data and the leaver definition. Section 3 draws the portrait of the teaching workforce and its evolution. Section 4 documents attrition over time and Section 5 where leavers go. Section 6 asks who leaves and Section 7 why. Section 8 profiles the typical leaver and Section 9 concludes with the policy implications.

2. Data

I use the basic monthly microdata of the Current Population Survey (CPS), the household survey behind the official employment statistics of the United States, which I assemble for every month between January 2005 and December 2025.² What makes the CPS useful for studying attrition is its rotation design, illustrated in Figure 1. Each household is interviewed during four consecutive months, rests for eight, and is interviewed again during four more, so that any person can be observed for at most sixteen months and only once in a lifetime. Within that window, an adult interviewed in year t is re-interviewed in the same calendar month of $t+1$, and I link the two interviews through household and person identifiers, validating every match on sex, race and a plausible age progression (Madrian and Lefgren, 2000). Because nobody is followed across several years, each base year forms a fresh cohort, and I compute every rate in this paper wave by wave over twenty waves.

Figure 1: The CPS follows each person for at most 16 months.



Notes: Interview calendar of one rotation group; numbers are months since the first interview. The 12-month link compares an interview from the first block with the interview held exactly one year later, and the return window uses the remaining interviews of the second block.

I identify teachers by the occupation of their main job, which covers classroom teaching from preschool

²The files come from the U.S. Census Bureau for 2024–2025 and from the NBER mirror for 2005–2023. October 2025 was never released because the federal government shutdown suspended that month’s data collection.

and kindergarten through elementary, middle and secondary school, together with special education,³ and I require at least a bachelor's degree, the standard restriction in the attrition literature. Pooling the twenty waves delivers 174,872 linked teachers who represent the 4.6 million teachers of the country. A leaver could simply be anyone not employed as a school teacher twelve months after baseline, which is the convention of the NCES Teacher Follow-up Survey (NCES, 2024), but temporary exits such as parental leave or a short unemployment spell inflate that measure, and indeed 15.7% of such leavers are teaching again within three months. My main outcome is therefore the non-returning leaver, a teacher who is out of teaching at $t+12$ and in every later re-interview, computed on the 129,897 teachers whose rotation allows at least one re-interview. Appendix A traces the full population funnel, shows that linkage failure does not select against teachers, reconciles my rates with the published benchmarks, and discusses the measurement caveats that make them upper bounds on permanent exit.

3. The typical teacher

Before asking who leaves, it helps to know who teaches. Table 1 draws that portrait on every person I observe in a school-teaching occupation over the two decades, 116,649 individuals who represent about 5.2 million teachers in an average month, split by sex and set against the rest of the college-educated workforce. The typical teacher is a married woman in her early forties with children at home, and she differs from other graduates on almost every margin the survey measures. Teaching is overwhelmingly female, at 78 against 47 percent, disproportionately white, and markedly less open to Asian and foreign-born graduates. Credentials cluster in the middle, since 88 percent of teachers hold at least a bachelor's degree and 45 percent a master's, ten points above other graduates, while doctorates remain rare. Almost three quarters work for the public sector against 15 percent elsewhere, and 45 percent are union members against 9 percent. Hours are standard full-time, and the price of this stability is pay, since the median teacher earns \$1,154 a week, roughly a quarter less than comparable college-educated workers.

The sex split carries its own message, because the minority of men who teach look systematically more attached to the core of the job, more often public-sector, unionized, full-time and holding a master's degree, and 11 percent of them hold a second job against 6 percent of women. The full age distributions and a visual summary of these contrasts are in Appendix Figures A1 and A2.

The profile has also been moving, and Figure 2 traces that movement year by year. The workforce is aging, with the share under 35 down from 32 to 29 percent, becoming markedly more Hispanic, from 6 to 13 percent, and steadily more credentialed, with bachelor's degrees edging up and master's degrees rising from 40 to 47 percent, while two anchors of the traditional teaching career erode at the same time, since public-sector employment falls from 75 to 69 percent of teachers and union membership from 49 to 42 percent. The gender mix, in contrast, has not moved at all. Teaching is drifting toward the private, non-union segment where, as the results below show, careers break most often. Appendix Table A3 reports the same evolution by sub-period together with formal tests, and every one of these changes is significant at the one percent level.

Weighted to population, the stock of degree-holding teachers, the group my attrition analysis follows, is remarkably stable at about 4.7 million over the whole period (Appendix Figure A3), with the composition

³These are Census occupation codes 2300 to 2330, where 2300 designates preschool and kindergarten teachers, 2310 elementary and middle school teachers, 2320 secondary school teachers and 2330 special education teachers. The codes are identical in the 2002, 2010 and 2020 occupational classifications used over the period, which keeps the series comparable for twenty-one years.

Table 1: Portrait of the American teaching workforce, 2005–2025.

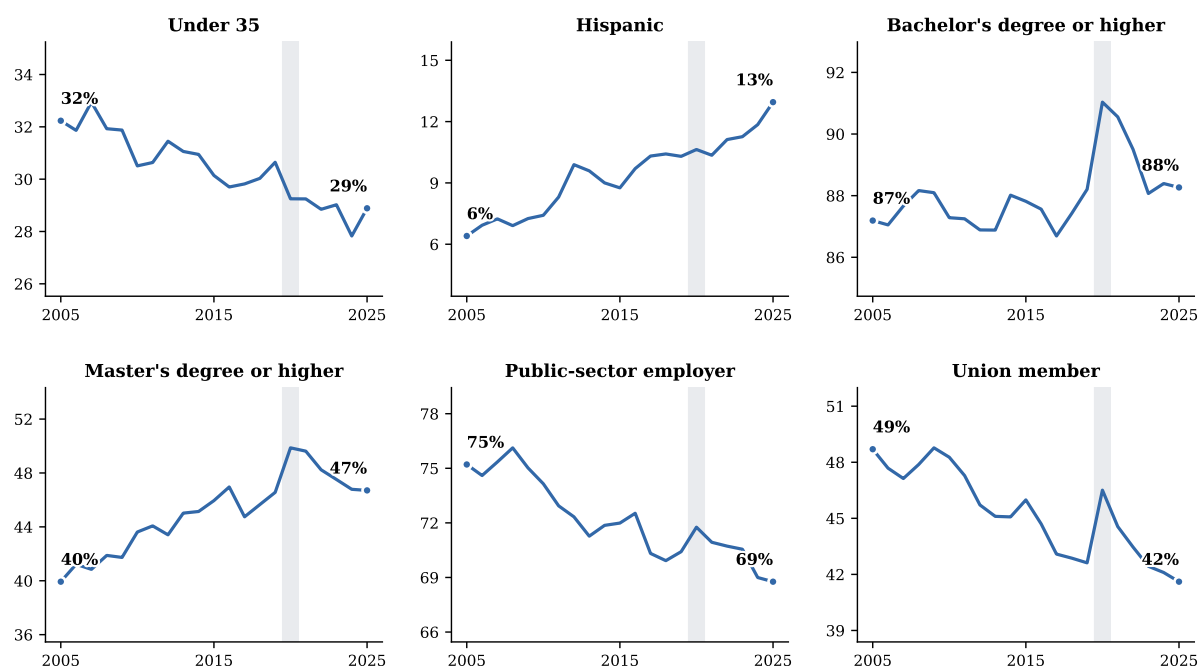
	School teachers			Other college- educated workers	Difference
	Women	Men	All		
Panel A. Demographics					
Age, years	42.6	43.1	42.7	43.8	-1.11***
Female			78.2%	47.3%	30.9***
White	84.8%	85.3%	84.9%	78.5%	6.4***
Black	10.3%	9.8%	10.2%	9.0%	1.2***
Asian	2.8%	2.6%	2.8%	10.3%	-7.5***
Hispanic	9.4%	9.3%	9.4%	8.3%	1.0***
Non-citizen	2.2%	2.3%	2.3%	7.2%	-4.9***
Panel B. Family					
Married	65.8%	69.1%	66.6%	63.8%	2.7***
Number of own children (<18) at home	0.8	0.8	0.8	0.6	0.15***
Child under 6 at home	16.7%	19.9%	17.4%	15.6%	1.8***
Panel C. Education					
Bachelor's degree or higher	86.2%	94.4%	88.0%	100.0%	-12.0***
Master's degree or higher	43.5%	50.8%	45.1%	34.5%	10.6***
Professional degree or doctorate	2.1%	3.9%	2.5%	10.5%	-8.0***
Panel D. The job					
Public-sector employer	70.5%	78.0%	72.1%	15.4%	56.8***
Union member ^a	43.9%	50.2%	45.3%	8.7%	36.6***
Usual weekly hours	39.5	41.4	39.9	40.4	-0.49***
Part-time (<35 h/week)	11.7%	6.8%	10.6%	12.3%	-1.7***
Holds more than one job	6.4%	11.3%	7.4%	6.1%	1.3***
Panel E. Pay and income					
Weekly earnings, median ^b	\$1,115	\$1,308	\$1,154	\$1,500	-\$346***
Family income \$75k+ ^b	81.1%	84.7%	81.9%	85.5%	-3.6***
Persons	92,044	24,812	116,649	963,782	
Population represented, millions ^c	4.1	1.1	5.2	49.6	

Notes: Weighted means over every employed person observed in a school-teaching occupation, with no degree restriction, pooling all 251 survey months; the comparison group is employed persons outside teaching holding at least a bachelor's degree. Sample sizes are unique persons, and a small number of persons with inconsistent sex codes across interviews appear in both sex columns. The last column reports the difference between all teachers and the comparison group, in percentage points for shares, and the significance of a two-sample test with standard errors clustered by household (** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$, $p < 0.1$).
^a Union membership and weekly earnings are only asked in the outgoing rotations, months in sample 4 and 8. ^b Measured over 2021–2025 only, to avoid mixing twenty years of price levels. ^c Population represented by the group in an average month. Source: author's calculations from CPS basic monthly microdata, 2005–2025.

by teaching level equally steady and dominated by elementary and middle school (shown in Appendix Figure A4). Stability of the stock, however, hides a great deal of movement underneath. Tracking the linked pairs in both directions, Figure 3 shows that teaching loses and recruits between 15 and 20 percent of its stock every single year, so the profession is best pictured as a large revolving door whose two flows roughly balance, although in recent years exits have run persistently above entries.

Geography adds a final layer to the portrait, and here the interesting map is not where teachers live but where they quit. Teachers are a somewhat larger share of employment in New England and parts of the rural South, around 3.8 percent in Connecticut, Vermont or Mississippi, than in Nevada or Florida, at 2.2 percent, but attrition varies far more. As Figure 4 shows, annual exit rates range from about 11 percent in the most retentive states to above 19 in the least, and the variation lines up with what schools produce.

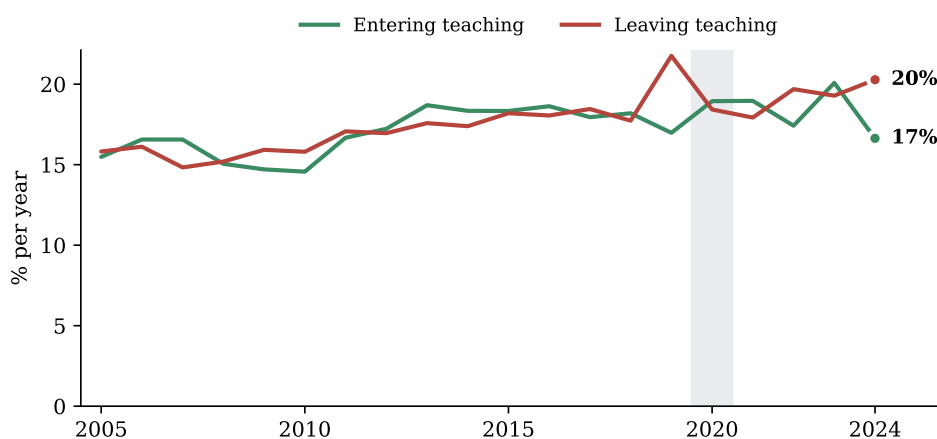
Figure 2: The changing profile of the teaching workforce.



Notes: Weighted annual means over all employed persons observed in a school-teaching occupation, with no degree restriction. Union membership is only asked in the outgoing rotations. The shaded band marks 2020. Appendix Table A3 reports the underlying numbers by sub-period with tests of the change. Source: author's calculations from CPS basic monthly microdata, 2005–2025.

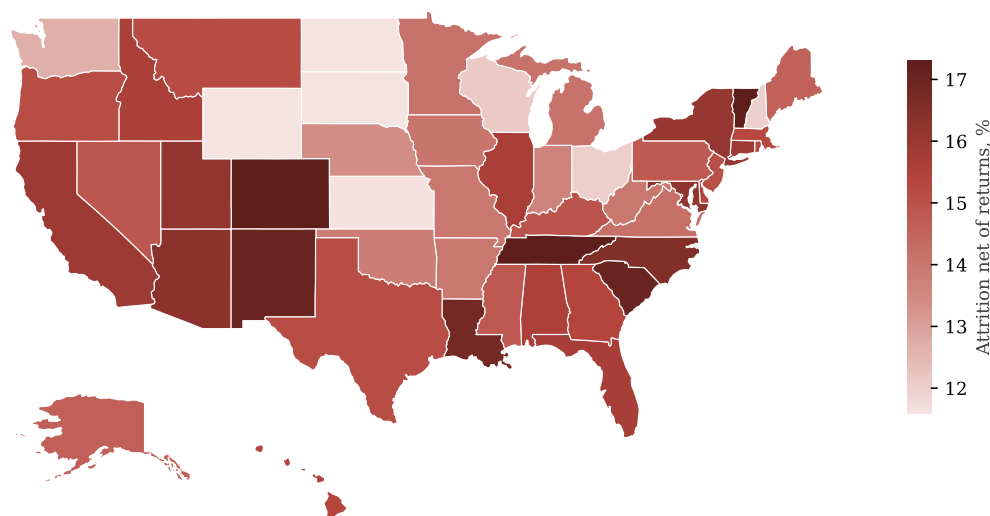
Linking each state to its official NAEP grade-8 mathematics score, the standard state measure of school quality, Figure 5 shows that states with better scores retain their teachers better, with a correlation of -0.47 and roughly one percentage point less attrition for every ten NAEP points. The direction of causality is of course open, since good schools may retain teachers and stable teaching forces may also produce good schools, but the association places teacher retention squarely inside the education-quality conversation.

Figure 3: Teachers entering and leaving each year.



Notes: Gross annual flows in the linked pairs under the 12-month definitions. A person enters teaching if she is a degree-holding school teacher at the second interview but was not one a year earlier, and leaves in the reverse case. Because the linked sample misses people who move, both flows are conservative. Source: author's calculations from linked CPS pairs, 2005–2025.

Figure 4: Where teachers leave: attrition by state, 2005–2025.



Notes: Weighted non-returning attrition rate by state, pooling all twenty waves. Rates for the smallest states rest on fewer observations and should be read with care. Source: author's calculations from linked CPS pairs, 2005–2025.

4. Attrition over time

One in six 12-month leavers is teaching again within three months, 16.1 percent of women and 14.0 percent of men, and these temporary exits are precisely what the non-returning definition strips out. Net of that churn, Figure 6 shows that attrition net of returns still climbed from about 13 percent in 2005–2010 to about 17 percent in 2022–2024, peaking at 18.4 percent in the pandemic year and reaching a new high of 18.0 percent in 2024. Gender gaps are small and unstable throughout, and in the most recent year men, at 19.8 percent, actually exceeded women, at 17.4.

5. Where leavers go

The linked design distinguishes those who abandon the labor force from those who change occupation, and for the latter it records the destination. Figure 7 shows that the single largest destination, at 30 percent of non-returning leavers, is another education job, whether postsecondary teaching, tutoring and instruction, teaching assistance, librarianship or school administration, so a large share of exits from classroom teaching never leave education at all. Retirement accounts for a further 17 percent, at a mean age of 62, and only 4 percent are unemployed a year later. The gender contrast is sharp exactly where the family results of the model will point, since 14 percent of women who leave are out of the labor force for reasons other than retirement or disability, at a mean age of 39 consistent with family care, against 5 percent of men, while men move more often into management and professional jobs, 26 against 19 percent.

The two margins have also moved differently over time. As Figure 8 makes clear, the rise in attrition documented in Section 4 is almost entirely a rise in occupation switching, from about 8.5 percent of teachers per year in the mid 2000s to 12 percent in 2022–2024, while exits into non-participation have stayed flat at 4 to 5 percent and unemployment spikes only in recessions. Teaching is increasingly losing

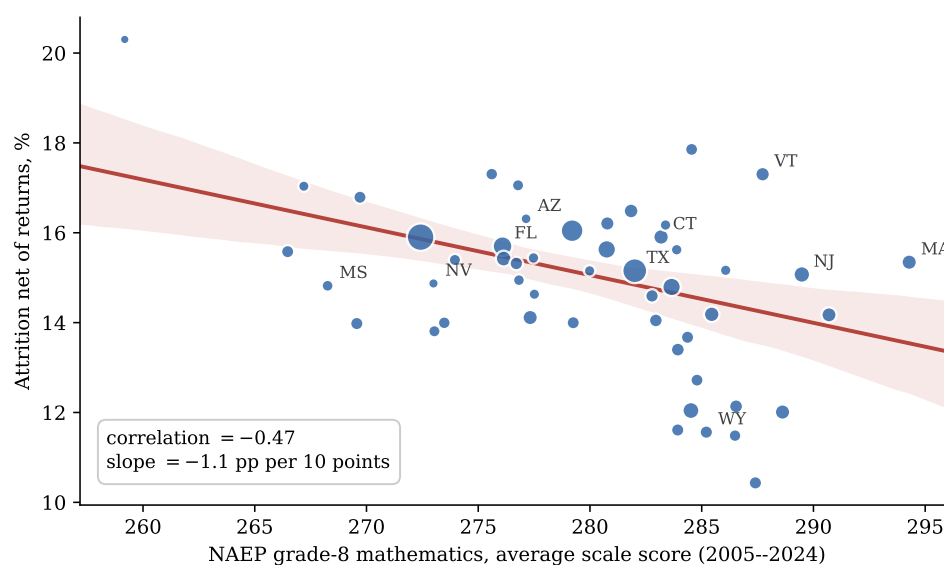
people to other jobs, not to inactivity. Mobility inside the profession is substantial as well, since among teachers who are still teaching a year later 6.7 percent have moved from a public to a private school and 5.8 percent in the opposite direction, figures that class-of-worker coding noise makes upper bounds but that echo the school-to-school mover rates the follow-up surveys report.

6. Who leaves

Appendix Table A4 opens the question by comparing stayers and non-returning leavers across every characteristic I observe, shading in green the differences that are both statistically significant and economically meaningful. Read as a whole, the table already sketches the profile of the leaver. Leavers are three years older on average, they are far more attached to the margins of the job than to its core, since working part-time is eleven points more common among them and private-sector employment fifteen points more common, and their family situation differs in a precise way, with fewer young children at home rather than more. The gender split, in contrast, is economically irrelevant, with women 76.8% of stayers and 77.0% of leavers, an early sign that gender operates through specific channels rather than through levels. Black and non-citizen teachers are clearly over-represented among leavers, and so are preschool and kindergarten teachers, while credentials matter in both directions, since leavers are less likely to hold a master's degree but almost twice as likely to hold a professional degree or doctorate. Most of these gaps are not marginal, as ten of them exceed two percentage points, the threshold I use for economic relevance. Expressed as exit rates, part-time teachers leave at more than twice the rate of full-time teachers, 32 against 13 percent, and preschool and kindergarten teachers face 21 percent against 15 for elementary and 13 for secondary school.

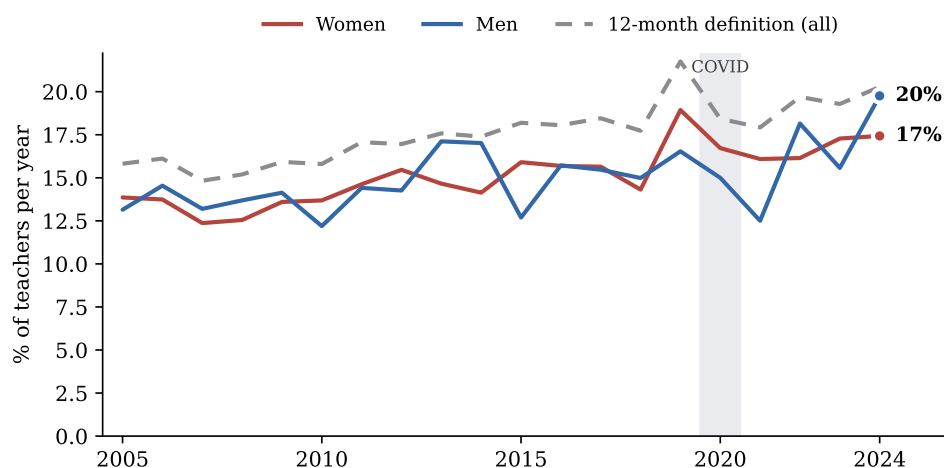
The lifecycle shape is visible in the raw data as well. Plotting attrition by birth cohort separately for men and women in Figure 9 traces the same U that the model will estimate, with cohorts born before 1950,

Figure 5: States with better NAEP scores lose fewer teachers.



Notes: Each dot is a state, sized by its number of linked teachers. The horizontal axis averages the official NAEP grade-8 mathematics scale score over the 2005–2024 state assessments, retrieved from the Nation’s Report Card data service; the vertical axis is the weighted non-returning attrition rate pooled over 2005–2025. The fitted line is weighted by sample size. Source: author’s calculations from linked CPS pairs and NAEP.

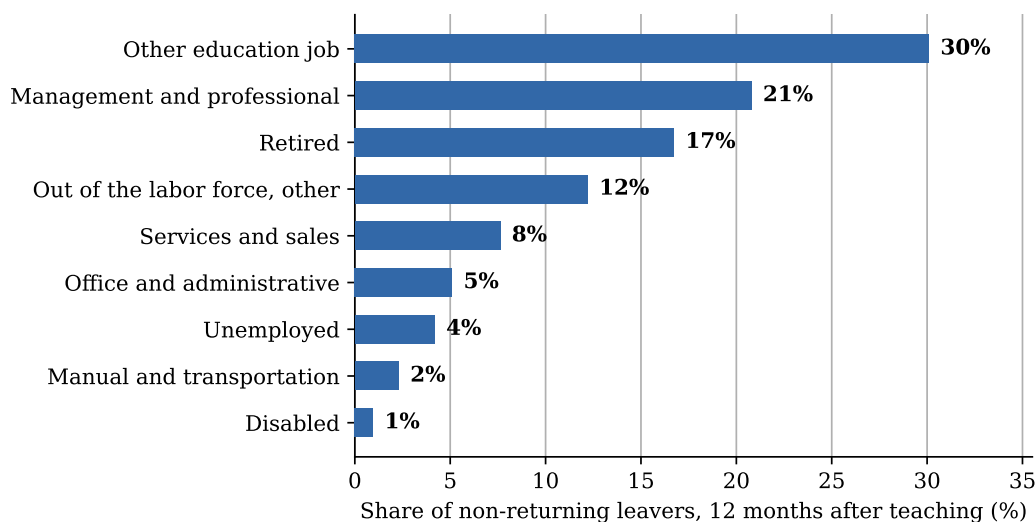
Figure 6: Attrition net of returns by year and gender.



Notes: The return window is capped by the survey design at three monthly interviews after the twelve-month link, and 21,873 of the 30,244 leavers are re-interviewed at least once. Source: author's calculations from linked CPS pairs, 2005–2025.

observed near retirement, leaving at 25 to 35 percent per year, mid-career cohorts at 11 to 13 percent, and the youngest climbing back to 18 percent. Men and women follow nearly the same curve, and the third line explains why the aggregate female curve hides the fertility margin. Among women with children at home, mid-life cohorts are the most stable group in the whole figure, a selection effect, while the youngest cohort of mothers leaves at almost 20 percent, the highest rate shown. Motherhood splits women into the most attached group and the most exit-prone one, and the average conceals both.

Figure 7: Situation of non-returning leavers twelve months after teaching.



Notes: Education jobs other than school teaching include postsecondary teaching, tutoring and instruction, teaching assistance, librarians and education administration, and the remaining employed leavers are grouped into broad occupation classes. Retirement, disability, unemployment and other non-participation come from the labor force status recorded at the second interview. Source: author's calculations from linked CPS pairs, 2005–2025.

7. Why teachers leave

To weigh all these characteristics against each other at once, I estimate a probit model for the probability that teacher i , observed in year t , leaves without an observed return,

$$\Pr(\text{leave}_i = 1 \mid x_i) = \Phi(x_i' \beta + \gamma_t), \quad (1)$$

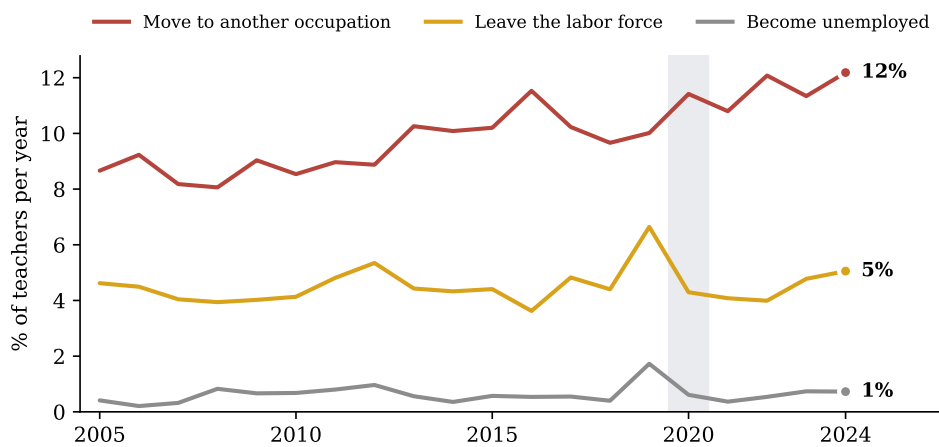
where x_i collects everything I observe about the teacher at baseline, from demographics and family structure to hours, sector and region, γ_t are base-year fixed effects that absorb anything common to all teachers in a given year, such as the pandemic, and Φ is the standard normal distribution function that converts the index into a probability. In plain terms, the model asks how much more or less likely a teacher is to leave when one characteristic changes and all the others are held fixed, and I report each estimate as an average marginal effect, the change in the probability of leaving measured in percentage points. These are conditional associations in observational data, and none of them should be read as a causal effect; the model describes who leaves, holding everything else constant, not what would happen if a policy changed any of these traits. Standard errors are clustered by household. Appendix Table A6 reports the full estimates and Figure 10 plots the marginal effects, organized by the block each variable belongs to.

The job margin dominates. A part-time teacher is 11.3 percentage points more likely to leave than an otherwise identical full-time colleague (Appendix Table A6, column 2, significant at 1 percent), and a private-school teacher is 7.5 points more likely to leave than a public-school one. Against a baseline exit rate of 15 percent, the two largest effects in the model amount to roughly three quarters and one half of the average risk.

Pay retains, modestly. Weekly earnings are only collected in the outgoing rotations, so I estimate the wage effect on that subsample of 44,823 teachers, where ten percent higher weekly earnings lower the probability of leaving by 0.3 percentage points, about two percent of the baseline rate.

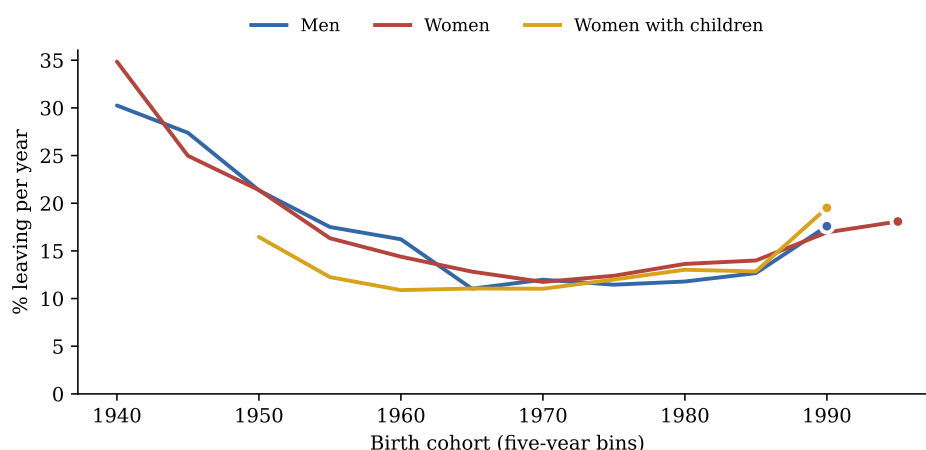
The family results separate stocks from events. The stock of children retains, at about one point less exit risk per own child at home (significant at 1 percent), while the event of a birth works in the opposite direction and only for women. A new baby during the year leaves men's exit probability unchanged, a

Figure 8: Leavers by destination over time.



Notes: Non-returning leavers as a share of baseline teachers in each year, split by their situation twelve months later. Source: author's calculations from linked CPS pairs, 2005–2025.

Figure 9: Attrition by birth cohort and sex.



Notes: Weighted non-returning attrition rate by five-year birth cohort, pooling all twenty waves, so each cohort is observed at the ages it reaches during 2005–2025 and the curve mixes age and cohort variation. Women with children are those with at least one own child under eighteen at home at baseline, and cells with fewer than 400 observations are omitted. Source: author's calculations from linked CPS pairs, 2005–2025.

precisely estimated zero with a p-value of 0.72, but raises women's by 5.1 points, significant at 5 percent and one third of the baseline risk, and 58 percent of the new mothers who leave exit the labor force entirely against 30 percent of the average leaver. This is the fertility channel the literature emphasizes (Stinebrickner, 2002), invisible when only the stock of children is used.

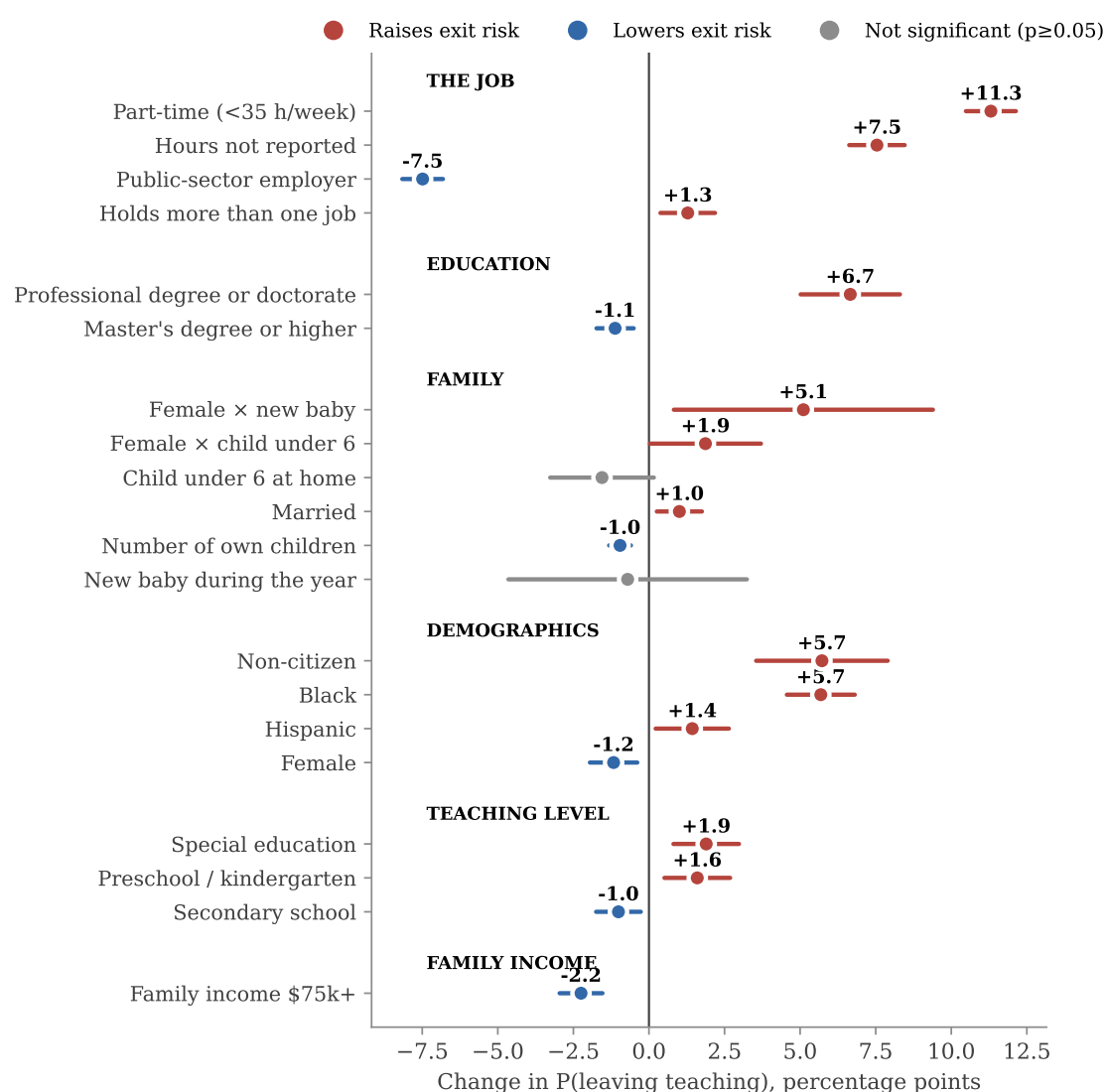
Minority and non-citizen teachers are significantly more likely to leave. Black teachers leave at 5.7 points above comparable white teachers and non-citizens at 5.7 points above citizens, both significant at 1 percent and each close to 40 percent of the baseline rate, while the Hispanic gap is a smaller 1.4 points, significant at 5 percent. These retention gaps compound into the diversity of the future workforce.

Credentials cut both ways, and age follows the familiar U. Relative to a bachelor's degree a master's retains modestly, while a professional degree or doctorate predicts 6.7 points more exit, significant at 1 percent and consistent with better options outside the classroom. The predicted probability of leaving falls to a minimum of 9 percent around age 39 and rises steeply after 55 (Appendix Figure A5). Every effect is nearly identical under the conventional 12-month definition, with the part-time effect at 13.6 points against 11.3, so the predictors do not depend on how leaving is measured.

None of this depends on the estimator. Re-estimating the same equation as a logit or as a linear probability model, or dropping the pandemic years 2019–2021 altogether, leaves every marginal effect essentially unchanged (Appendix Table A5); the part-time effect, for instance, moves between 10.8 and 14.7 points across the four variants and the female new-baby effect stays between 5.1 and 5.3.

Estimating the same model on subsamples, as Appendix Figure A6 does, confirms that the job effects are strikingly universal, with part-time work raising exit risk by 11 to 13 points for women and men, in public and private schools, below and above age 40, and the public-sector advantage at 7 to 8 points in every cut. The fertility effect, in contrast, is entirely female, and the Black retention gap appears in every subsample, largest in private schools.

Figure 10: Average marginal effects on the probability of leaving teaching, with 95% confidence intervals.



Notes: Estimates from the probit of Table A6. The age profile is shown in Appendix Figure A5. Region indicators and the hours-not-reported indicator are included in the model but not displayed.

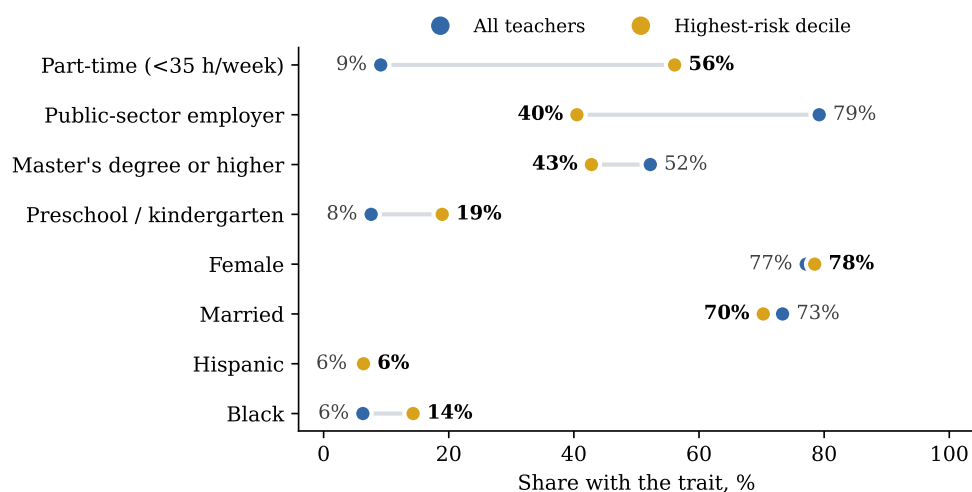
8. The typical leaver

Ranking teachers by their predicted risk gives the model's portrait of the typical leaver, drawn in Figure 11. The top decile faces a mean exit probability of 37 percent, 2.5 times the average teacher, and it is overwhelmingly female, at 79 percent, late-career with a mean age of 55, six times more likely to work part-time, 56 against 9 percent, and much less anchored in the public sector, where only 40 percent of the group works against 78 percent of all teachers, with Black teachers over-represented at 14 against 6 percent.

9. Policy implications

The results locate attrition in weak attachment to the job, in part-time hours, private-sector positions and both career extremes, rather than in broad demographics, with a rising trend made almost entirely of moves to other occupations. Four levers follow directly. Converting involuntary part-time positions to

Figure 11: Characteristics of the top predicted-risk decile vs all teachers.



Notes: Predicted probabilities from the probit of Table A6. Source: author's calculations from linked CPS pairs, 2005–2025.

full-time attacks the single largest risk factor, and the wage result implies that pay raises retain, though modestly. The private sector is where teaching careers break, and part of the preschool exposure reflects that composition. The Black, Hispanic and non-citizen retention gaps deserve monitoring for the diversity of the future workforce. And with one in six leavers back within three months, cheap re-entry pathways such as fast-track rehiring and return bonuses can recover part of the outflow at low cost.

References

- Aldeman, Chad, and Samuel Yi. 2025. "Are Teachers Abandoning Teaching? Data Show Teacher Turnover Remains Low." *Education Next*.
- Bacher-Hicks, Andrew, Olivia L. Chi, and Alexis Orellana. 2023. "Two Years Later: How COVID-19 Has Shaped the Teacher Workforce." *Educational Researcher*, 52(4), 219–229.
- Bastian, Kevin C., and Sarah C. Fuller. 2023. "Educator Attrition and Mobility During the COVID-19 Pandemic." *Educational Researcher*, 52(8), 516–520.
- Biasi, Barbara. 2021. "The Labor Market for Teachers under Different Pay Schemes." *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, 13(3), 63–102.
- Camp, Andrew, Gema Zamorro, and Josh B. McGee. 2025. "Looking Back and Moving Forward: COVID-19's Impact on the Teacher Labor Market and Implications for the Future." *Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis*.
- Chetty, Raj, John N. Friedman, and Jonah E. Rockoff. 2014. "Measuring the Impacts of Teachers II: Teacher Value-Added and Student Outcomes in Adulthood." *American Economic Review*, 104(9), 2633–2679.
- Goldhaber, Dan, and Roddy Theobald. 2023. "Teacher Attrition and Mobility in the Pandemic." *Educational Evaluation and Policy Analysis*, 45(4), 682–687.
- Hanushek, Eric A., John F. Kain, and Steven G. Rivkin. 2004. "Why Public Schools Lose Teachers." *Journal of Human Resources*, 39(2), 326–354.
- Harris, Douglas N., and Scott J. Adams. 2007. "Understanding the Level and Causes of Teacher Turnover: A Comparison with Other Professions." *Economics of Education Review*, 26(3), 325–337.
- Ingersoll, Richard M. 2001. "Teacher Turnover and Teacher Shortages: An Organizational Analysis." *American Educational Research Journal*, 38(3), 499–534.
- Madrian, Brigitte C., and Lars J. Lefgren. 2000. "An Approach to Longitudinally Matching Current Population Survey (CPS) Respondents." *Journal of Economic and Social Measurement*, 26(1), 31–62.
- National Center for Education Statistics (NCES). 2024. "Teacher Attrition and Mobility: Results from the 2021–22 Teacher Follow-up Survey." NCES 2024-039, U.S. Department of Education.
- Nguyen, Tuan D., Lam D. Pham, Michael Crouch, and Matthew G. Springer. 2020. "The Correlates of Teacher Turnover: An Updated and Expanded Meta-analysis of the Literature." *Educational Research Review*, 31, 100355.
- Rivkin, Steven G., Eric A. Hanushek, and John F. Kain. 2005. "Teachers, Schools, and Academic Achievement." *Econometrica*, 73(2), 417–458.
- Ronfeldt, Matthew, Susanna Loeb, and James Wyckoff. 2013. "How Teacher Turnover Harms Student Achievement." *American Educational Research Journal*, 50(1), 4–36.
- Stinebrickner, Todd R. 2002. "An Analysis of Occupational Change and Departure from the Labor Force: Evidence of the Reasons that Teachers Leave." *Journal of Human Resources*, 37(1), 192–216.

Appendix A. Sample construction and representativeness

This appendix documents how the analytic sample is built from the raw survey, how representative it remains after linkage, and the measurement limits a reader should keep in mind.

Table A1 traces how the CPS universe narrows down to my analytic sample. In an average month the survey interviews close to 95,000 adults who represent 241 million people, of whom about 1,850 are employed school teachers with at least a bachelor’s degree, representing the 4.6 million teachers of the country. The degree requirement removes a small group of daycare and substitute personnel. Only the half of the sample that is in its first rotation block can be linked one year ahead, and the linkage itself succeeds for 78 percent of teachers. Reassuringly, it succeeds less often for everyone else, 74 percent among other college-educated workers and 71 percent among all employed, a ranking that holds in every single year, so sample losses do not select against teachers. Losses arise because the CPS samples addresses rather than people, which means movers drop out, and since moving is correlated with changing jobs my attrition rates are conservative on this margin. Linked persons keep their population weights, so all weighted rates remain representative of the 4.6 million teachers.

Table A1: From the CPS universe to the analytic sample.

	Persons	Population represented
Adults interviewed in an average month	94,630	240.6M
employed	57,572	148.1M
school teachers (occ. 2300–2330)	2,094	5.2M
with bachelor’s degree or higher	1,849	4.6M
Linked 12 months later (unique persons, 20 waves)	174,872	the same 4.6M
with re-interviews after $t+12$: main sample	129,897	the same 4.6M

Notes: Monthly figures are averages over the 251 available months, with weighted population totals beside the sample counts. Teachers are employed persons whose main job is school teaching (Census occupation codes 2300 to 2330) holding a bachelor’s degree or higher. Source: author’s calculations from CPS basic monthly microdata, 2005–2025.

Two measurement caveats apply throughout. First, my observation window is genuinely short. A person leaves the survey for good at most sixteen months after entering it, so a teacher who returns to the classroom more than a few months after the twelve-month link is still counted as a leaver, and all my attrition rates are upper bounds on permanent exit. Measuring multi-year exits and returns would require a long panel such as the SIPP or the NLSY. Second, occupation in the returning rotation is re-coded independently, which mechanically inflates measured switching, so levels should again be read as upper bounds while comparisons across groups and over time, the object of this paper, are far less affected.

How do these rates compare with the published benchmarks? Table A2 walks the distance step by step. Restricting my conventional 12-month rate to the universe the Teacher Follow-up Survey covers, public school teachers outside preschool, lowers it from 17.6 to 15.2 percent, purging observed returns lowers it to 15.1, and counting as leavers only those found in no education occupation at $t+12$ lowers it to 10.5. The remaining gap to the 8.0 percent of the follow-up survey and to the 7.6 to 7.7 percent of the retrospective CPS studies reflects the measurement instrument itself. My design re-codes occupation independently at the second interview, which inflates measured switching, while the retrospective question compares two answers given in a single interview, which is known to understate occupational change, so the truth plausibly lies between the two families of estimates. To pin down the role of the instrument with my own data, I replicate the retrospective measure on the 2022–2024 March supplements, defining a teacher by the longest job of the previous calendar year and a leaver by the occupation of the survey week. The same

survey that yields 17.6 percent under the linked design yields 5.8 percent under the retrospective question, and the decomposition is telling, since the retrospective instrument records only 1.9 percentage points of moves into other occupations against about 12 in the linked pairs, while the non-employment margin is similar in both. What the within-interview question misses is precisely the job-to-job margin that drives my series. The address-based design also means I follow dwellings rather than people, and indeed not a single continuing teacher in my linked sample changes state, so cross-district and cross-state moves are invisible here and my rates are conservative on that margin.

Table A2: From this paper’s definitions to the published benchmarks.

	Annual rate	Persons
Conventional 12-month leaver, all teachers	17.6%	174,872
public-sector teachers only	15.1%	138,504
excluding preschool and kindergarten	17.1%	161,606
public sector and K–12 only	15.2%	132,097
Non-returning leaver (main definition)	15.1%	129,897
and in no education occupation at $t+12$	10.5%	129,897
<i>Retrospective and survey benchmarks</i>		
My replication on the 2022–2024 March supplements	5.8%	6,945
Harris and Adams (2007), 1992–2001	7.7%	
Aldeman and Yi (2025), 2015–2024	7.6%	
Teacher Follow-up Survey 2021–22 (NCES, 2024)	8.0%	

Notes: Weighted annual rates. The first four rows apply the conventional 12-month definition to all linked teachers and to progressively restricted universes; the last two rows apply the non-returning definition on the baseline subsample whose rotation allows re-interviews, with the final row counting as leavers only teachers found in no education occupation twelve months after baseline. The replication row applies the retrospective definition to the 2022–2024 March supplements, with teachers identified by the longest job of the previous calendar year, a bachelor’s degree requirement, and leaving defined by the survey-week occupation. The remaining benchmark rows quote the public school leaver rate of the 2021–22 Teacher Follow-up Survey (NCES, 2024) and the retrospective March CPS estimates of Harris and Adams (2007) and Aldeman and Yi (2025). Source: author’s calculations from linked CPS pairs, 2005–2025.

Appendix B. Additional figures and tables

This appendix collects the supporting material referenced in the main text, moving from description to estimation. It shows the age and composition contrasts behind Table 1, the stock of teachers and its composition by teaching level, the sub-period profile of the workforce and the stayer-leaver comparison, and then the model material, namely the predicted age profile, the subsample estimates, the estimator robustness checks and the full regression output.

Table A3: The changing profile of the teaching workforce, by sub-period.

	2005–2011	2012–2018	2019–2025	Change
Age, years	42.3	42.8	42.9	0.63***
Under 35	31.7%	30.4%	29.1%	-2.6***
Female	78.3%	78.3%	78.0%	-0.3
White	86.7%	84.9%	83.1%	-3.7***
Hispanic	7.2%	9.7%	11.2%	4.0***
Married	68.0%	66.9%	64.8%	-3.2***
Child under 6 at home	18.3%	18.0%	15.9%	-2.4***
Bachelor's degree or higher	87.5%	87.3%	89.1%	1.6***
Master's degree or higher	41.9%	45.3%	47.9%	6.0***
Public-sector employer	74.8%	71.4%	70.3%	-4.5***
Union member	48.0%	44.6%	43.3%	-4.6***
Part-time	11.2%	11.4%	9.4%	-1.8***
Persons	43,697	44,405	35,890	

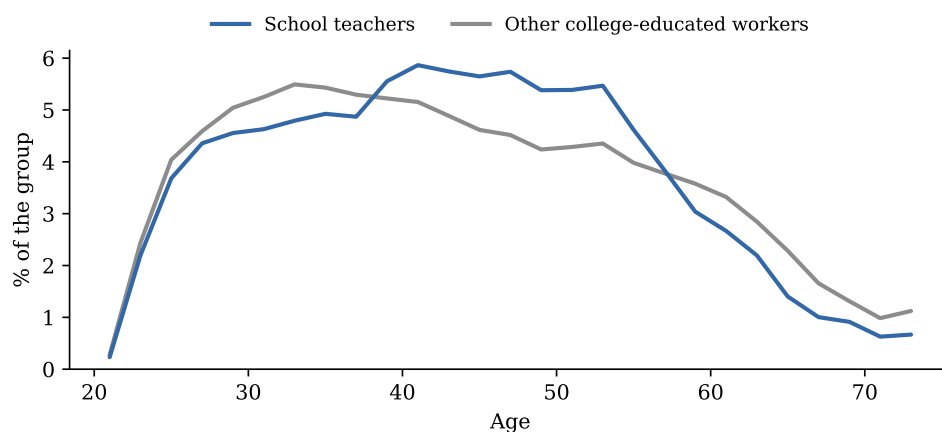
Notes: Weighted means over all employed persons observed in a school-teaching occupation, with no degree restriction, in each sub-period. Sample sizes are unique persons. The last column reports the change between 2005–2011 and 2019–2025, in percentage points for shares, and the significance of a two-sample test with standard errors clustered by household (*** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$). Union membership is only asked in the outgoing rotations. Source: author's calculations from CPS basic monthly microdata, 2005–2025.

Table A4: Stayers vs non-returning leavers in the analytic sample (weighted means).

	All teachers	Stayers	Non-returning leavers	Difference
Age, years	44.0	43.5	46.7	3.15***
Female	76.8%	76.8%	77.0%	0.2
Female aged 25–44	37.8%	38.8%	31.7%	-7.1***
Married	72.0%	72.5%	69.5%	-3.0***
Number of own children (<18) at home	0.8	0.9	0.6	-0.22***
Child under 6 at home	18.1%	18.9%	13.9%	-5.0***
New baby during the year	2.5%	2.5%	2.8%	0.3
Black	8.1%	7.5%	11.6%	4.2***
Hispanic	7.9%	7.8%	8.5%	0.7*
Non-citizen	1.7%	1.5%	3.0%	1.5***
Master's degree or higher	52.9%	53.7%	48.4%	-5.3***
Professional degree or doctorate	2.8%	2.5%	4.4%	2.0***
Part-time (<35 h/week)	9.0%	7.2%	19.1%	11.9***
Holds more than one job	8.1%	7.9%	9.4%	1.5***
Public-sector employer	78.3%	80.5%	65.7%	-14.9***
Family income \$75k+	76.4%	77.3%	71.4%	-5.9***
Elementary / middle school	61.8%	61.9%	61.2%	-0.7
Preschool / kindergarten	7.7%	7.1%	10.6%	3.5***
Secondary school	23.1%	23.5%	20.5%	-3.0***
Special education	7.5%	7.5%	7.6%	0.1
Persons	129,897	110,720	19,177	

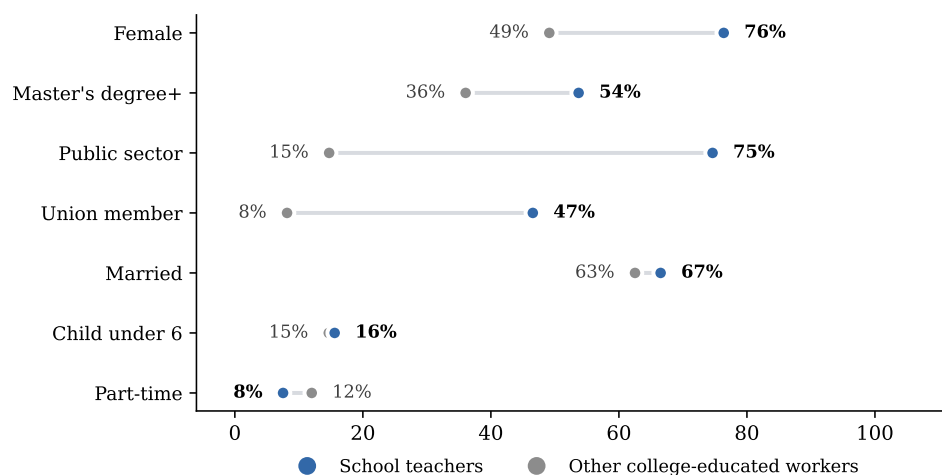
Notes: The sample is all linked teachers whose rotation includes at least one interview after the twelve-month link. All variables are measured at baseline and weighted with CPS person weights. Children are own children under eighteen living in the household at the time of the interview. The last column reports the stayer-leaver difference, in percentage points for shares, and the significance of a two-sample test with standard errors clustered by household (*** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$); green cells mark differences that are significant at 5 percent and larger than two percentage points (one year of age, 0.15 children). Source: author's calculations from CPS basic monthly microdata, 2005–2025.

Figure A1: Age distribution of school teachers and of other college-educated workers, 2021–2025.



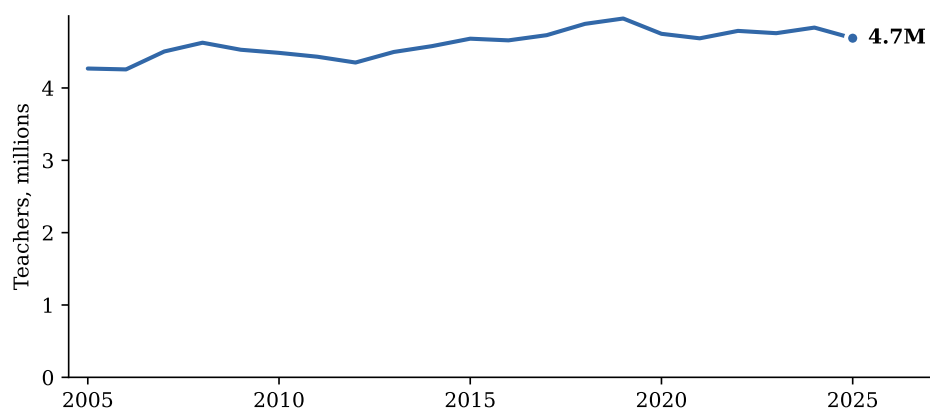
Notes: Both groups are employed persons with at least a bachelor's degree, and teachers are identified as in Table A1. Weighted to population. Source: author's calculations from CPS basic monthly microdata, 2021–2025.

Figure A2: Composition of the teaching workforce vs other college-educated workers, 2021–2025.



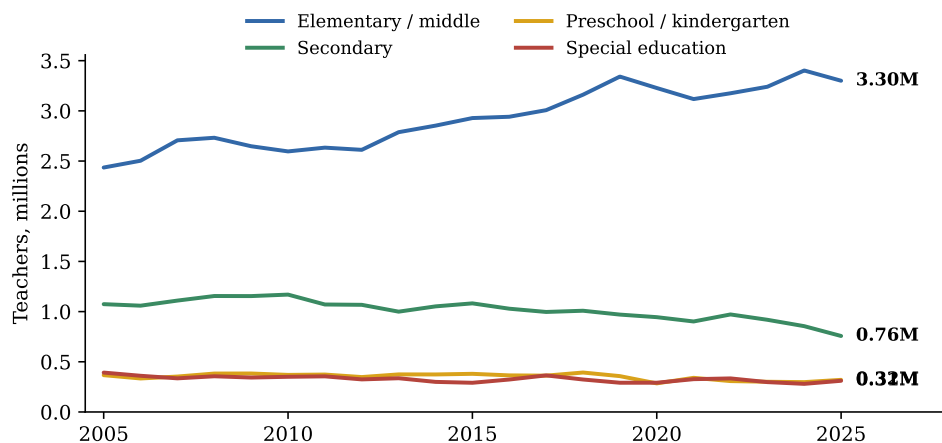
Notes: Same groups as Figure A1. Union membership is only asked in the outgoing rotations. Shares are weighted to population. Source: author's calculations from CPS basic monthly microdata, 2021–2025.

Figure A3: The stock of school teachers.



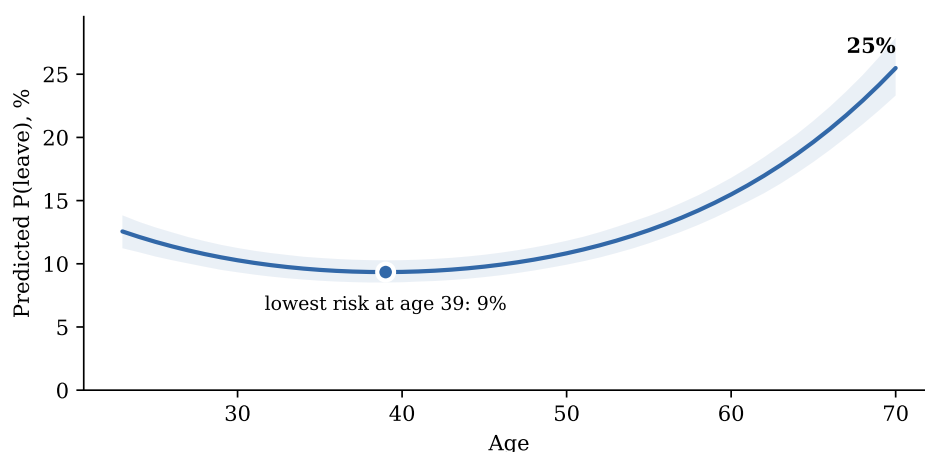
Notes: Employed school teachers with a bachelor's degree or higher, annual average of monthly weighted estimates. Source: author's calculations from CPS basic monthly microdata, 2005–2025.

Figure A4: Teachers by teaching level.



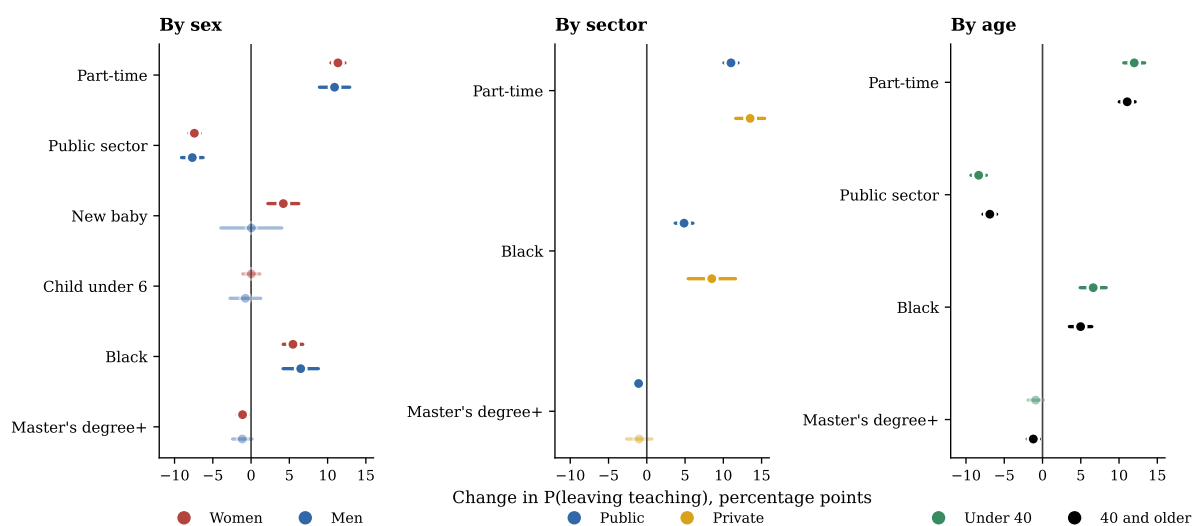
Notes: Same identification as Figure A3, split by occupation code. Source: author's calculations from CPS basic monthly microdata, 2005–2025.

Figure A5: Predicted probability of leaving by age.



Notes: Predicted probabilities from the probit of Table A6, holding all other covariates at their sample means, with a simulation-based 95% confidence band. Source: author's calculations from linked CPS pairs, 2005–2025.

Figure A6: The same model estimated on subsamples.



Notes: Average marginal effects with 95% confidence intervals from the probit of Table A6 estimated separately on each subsample; lighter marks are not significant at the 5 percent level. The birth and young-child effects are shown only in the sex panel because they are sex-specific. Source: author's calculations from linked CPS pairs, 2005–2025.

Table A5: Robustness to estimator and sample. Dependent variable equals one for non-returning leavers.

	(1) Probit (baseline)	(2) Logit	(3) Linear probability model	(4) Probit, excl. 2019–2021
Part-time (<35 h/week)	11.31*** (0.42)	10.78*** (0.40)	14.70*** (0.63)	10.75*** (0.45)
Public-sector employer	-7.49*** (0.34)	-7.33*** (0.34)	-8.43*** (0.43)	-7.50*** (0.37)
Professional degree or doctorate	6.66*** (0.84)	6.48*** (0.80)	7.89*** (1.12)	6.38*** (0.90)
Master's degree or higher	-1.12*** (0.31)	-1.18*** (0.32)	-0.99*** (0.31)	-1.12*** (0.33)
Black	5.68*** (0.57)	5.60*** (0.56)	6.42*** (0.72)	5.57*** (0.61)
Non-citizen	5.72*** (1.11)	5.53*** (1.05)	7.26*** (1.54)	5.76*** (1.18)
New baby during the year	-0.71 (2.01)	-0.91 (2.13)	-0.53 (1.70)	-0.51 (2.11)
Female × new baby	5.11** (2.19)	5.31** (2.28)	5.18*** (1.97)	5.15** (2.29)
Number of own children	-0.96*** (0.18)	-1.04*** (0.19)	-0.65*** (0.17)	-0.87*** (0.20)
Family income \$75k+	-2.25*** (0.36)	-2.21*** (0.36)	-2.37*** (0.39)	-2.26*** (0.38)
Female	-1.17*** (0.40)	-1.17*** (0.40)	-1.24*** (0.42)	-1.66*** (0.42)
Base-year fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Full covariate set	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mean of dependent variable	0.148	0.148	0.148	0.145
Persons	129,897	129,897	129,897	113,751

Notes: Each column re-estimates the full specification of Appendix Table A6 on the same analytic sample. Columns (1), (2) and (4) report average marginal effects in percentage points from probit and logit models; column (3) reports linear probability model coefficients multiplied by one hundred, so all four columns are directly comparable. Column (4) drops the 2019–2021 base years. All models are estimated without survey weights and include base-year fixed effects; delta-method standard errors clustered by household in parentheses. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.

Table A6: Determinants of leaving teaching. Probit, dependent variable equals one for non-returning leavers, 2005–2025.

	Leaves teaching with no observed return	
	(1) Probit coefficients	(2) Marginal effect (percentage points)
Age (years)	-0.053*** (0.004)	-1.14*** (0.09)
Age ² /100	0.068*** (0.004)	1.46*** (0.09)
Female	-0.055*** (0.019)	-1.17*** (0.40)
Married	0.047*** (0.018)	1.01*** (0.38)
Number of own children	-0.045*** (0.009)	-0.96*** (0.18)
Child under 6 at home	-0.072* (0.041)	-1.55* (0.87)
Female × child under 6	0.087** (0.044)	1.87** (0.94)
New baby during the year	-0.033 (0.094)	-0.71 (2.01)
Female × new baby	0.238** (0.102)	5.11** (2.19)
Black	0.265*** (0.027)	5.68*** (0.57)
Hispanic	0.067** (0.029)	1.43** (0.62)
Non-citizen	0.267*** (0.052)	5.72*** (1.11)
Master's degree or higher	-0.052*** (0.015)	-1.12*** (0.31)
Professional degree or doctorate	0.311*** (0.039)	6.66*** (0.84)
Part-time (<35 h/week)	0.528*** (0.020)	11.31*** (0.42)
Hours not reported	0.352*** (0.022)	7.54*** (0.47)
Holds more than one job	0.060*** (0.021)	1.28*** (0.46)
Public-sector employer	-0.349*** (0.016)	-7.49*** (0.34)
Family income \$75k+	-0.105*** (0.017)	-2.25*** (0.36)
Midwest	-0.082*** (0.021)	-1.76*** (0.45)
South	0.007 (0.020)	0.15 (0.42)
West	-0.017 (0.021)	-0.36 (0.45)
Preschool / kindergarten	0.075*** (0.026)	1.60*** (0.55)
Secondary school	-0.047*** (0.018)	-1.01*** (0.38)
Special education	0.088*** (0.026)	1.89*** (0.55)
Base-year fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Mean of dependent variable	0.148	0.148
Persons	129,897	129,897
Pseudo R^2	0.068	

Notes: The outcome is the non-returning leaver defined in Section 2. Column (1) reports probit coefficients and column (2) the corresponding average marginal effects in percentage points, with standard errors below each estimate, delta-method in column (2). The sample is all school teachers with a bachelor's degree or higher whose rotation includes at least one interview after the twelve-month link; the model is estimated without survey weights. Reference categories are full-time hours, a bachelor's degree, a private-sector employer, elementary or middle school, and the Northeast region. These estimates are conditional associations, not causal effects. *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$.